After the death of Ochterlony in 1825, the man who had to deal with such disputes was the new Ludhiana Agent, Captain Claude Martin Wade.

Wade was a Bengal-born Persian scholar, and godson of the French adventurer Claude Martin, who had lent money to Wade's impecunious father and after whom he was named. It was Wade's French connections that helped secure him the job of dealing with the Sikh court, as Ranjit Singh's power rested on his remarkable army, the Sikh Khalsa, 85,000 strong, which in turn was trained and officered by a small group of French and Italian Napoleonic veterans. All of these had married locally and produced large half-Punjabi families. Thanks to Wade, these ex-Napoleonic officers became an important source of information about Central Asia for the British.[i] Wade made a point of being friendly to them and was described by one appreciative French traveller as 'the King of the Frontier and an excellent fellow . . . a clever, well-informed man whose society is equally profitable and agreeable'.[43] His own despatches, however, paint a more complex picture: Wade was affable, certainly, but also shrewd, dry, penetrating and cynical. When crossed he could also be prickly and territorial, strongly resisting any attempts to break his monopoly on controlling British relations with both the Sikhs and Afghans.

From the day of his arrival in the town in 1823, Wade worked to revive the extensive news-writing and intelligence networks left in place by Elphinstone when he retreated from Peshawar and which had been neglected as unnecessary expenses since the passing of the Napoleonic threat. Wade also established a web of his own correspondents stretching through the Punjab and Afghanistan to Khiva, Bukhara and beyond, collecting information mainly through 'intelligent natives specially despatched'.[44] This information was collated, sifted and analysed, then sent on to his masters in Calcutta. Though the boundaries between news-writers, 'intelligencers' and outright spies were very porous at this period, Wade was effectively one of the first two spymasters of what later generations would call the Great Game, that grand contest of imperial competition, espionage and conquest that engaged Britain and Russia until the collapse of their respective Asian empires, and whose opening moves were being played at this period.[45]

Wade's great rival in this work was an Anglo-Irish bulldog named Sir Henry Pottinger, who from the Gujarati town of Bhuj in Kutch ran a competing operation on behalf of the Bombay Presidency, with a particular